

First 24/48 Hours Cyber Incident Checklist

Printable leadership checklist for the first two days of a major cybersecurity incident

OWNER
CTO / Cybersecurity
Coordinator

DISTRICT
Ardent ISD

REVIEW CYCLE
Annual + after major
incident

**POLICY CROSS-
REFERENCE**

CQB

Incident Response Plan

Training Sample - Customize Before Use. This document is an instructional artifact for Ardent ISD. It should be aligned to current board policy, administrative procedures, cyber-insurance requirements, records-retention requirements, and advice of district legal counsel before operational use. Legal and reporting requirements can change.

Print and store an offline copy. During a serious incident, email, cloud storage, SSO, phones, and district websites may be unavailable or untrusted.

Incident Header

Field	Entry
Incident ID	
Discovery date/time	
Incident lead	
Initial severity	☐ 1 Event ☐ 2 Limited ☐ 3 Major ☐ 4 Crisis
Systems/data suspected	
Next executive update	

0-2 Hours: Validate, Stabilize, Preserve

- ☐ Open Artifact 3 incident intake/triage record and assign an incident ID.
- ☐ Confirm a trusted communications channel for the incident team.
- ☐ Preserve the original alert, email, screenshot, logs, and relevant timestamps.
- ☐ Identify affected accounts, devices, applications, networks, vendors, and data.
- ☐ Isolate affected systems/accounts when doing so will reduce harm.

- ☐ Do not wipe, reimage, factory-reset, or discard potentially relevant devices/logs.
- ☐ Protect backup systems and administrative accounts from the same compromise.
- ☐ Notify CTO/Cybersecurity Coordinator and Superintendent based on severity.
- ☐ Notify District General Counsel when protected data, extortion, law enforcement, or public notice may be involved.
- ☐ Notify cyber insurer/breach coach according to policy requirements.

2-6 Hours: Scope and Coordinate

- ☐ Activate the cross-functional incident team for Level 3-4 events.
- ☐ Establish incident objectives for the next operational period: contain, preserve, understand, communicate, recover.
- ☐ Start a written decision log: decision, owner, time, rationale.
- ☐ Record the legal clock dates separately: discovery date; determination-of-breach date; eradication; closure; recovery.
- ☐ Identify likely critical-service impacts: safety, internet, identity, SIS, ERP/payroll, transportation, phones, websites, learning systems.
- ☐ Determine whether a third-party vendor is involved and preserve the contract/DPA.
- ☐ Determine whether law enforcement or external forensic support is appropriate.
- ☐ Prepare a short internal holding statement for staff leaders; do not overstate facts.

6-24 Hours: Reporting, Containment, Continuity

- ☐ Use Artifact 4 to evaluate Texas Cyber Command, Education Code, OAG, parent, employee, insurer, and contractual notices.
- ☐ If reportable to Texas Cyber Command, report as soon as possible; the current state page strongly encourages within 24 hours and states a 48-hour statutory deadline.
- ☐ Confirm who is authorized to communicate with TXCC, TEA/state systems, OAG, law enforcement, insurer, vendors, and media.
- ☐ Implement short-term containment: account lockout, token revocation, firewall/DNS blocks, vendor access suspension, segment isolation, or other approved measures.
- ☐ Verify whether backups are isolated, recent, readable, and not obviously affected.
- ☐ Identify manual workarounds for critical school operations.
- ☐ Prepare executive brief (Artifact 7) with known facts, unknowns, risks, decisions needed, and next update time.
- ☐ Prepare public/family communications only if needed and after legal review.

24-48 Hours: Deepen Scope and Build Recovery Plan

- ☐ Confirm incident timeline and earliest known malicious activity.
- ☐ Identify all compromised credentials and privileged accounts.
- ☐ Confirm data categories potentially viewed, copied, altered, encrypted, or exfiltrated.
- ☐ Establish recovery sequence and validation criteria for each critical service.

- ☐ Draft any legally required individual, parent, employee, or regulator notices using Artifacts 5-6 and legal review.
- ☐ Set a recurring executive/board update cadence.
- ☐ Track direct costs, vendor time, overtime, replacement equipment, identity protection, and insurance claim numbers.
- ☐ Preserve evidence and records under direction of counsel/records management.
- ☐ Document unresolved questions and assign owners.
- ☐ Schedule the first after-action review date, even if recovery will continue for weeks.

Escalate Immediately If Any of These Are True

Escalation triggers: ransomware/extortion; confirmed data exfiltration; privileged/admin account compromise; backup compromise; districtwide authentication outage; SIS/ERP/payroll interruption; safety-system impact; active fraud/wire-transfer attempt; media contact; threat actor contact; student health/special education records involved; Social Security numbers or financial credentials involved.

Quick Texas Clock Card

ASAP / 24h preferred

State cyber reporting when applicable; current TXCC guidance strongly encourages reporting within 24 hours.

48 hours

Current TXCC page states statutory reporting deadline for covered incidents affecting school districts/ local governments.

30 days

Texas AG notice for a Chapter 521 breach involving at least 250 Texas residents, measured from determination that a breach occurred.

60 days

General outer deadline for affected-person notice under Texas B&C §521.053, subject to statutory exceptions and counsel review.

Post-recovery: TXCC's current guidance states the follow-up cause analysis is due by the **10th business day after eradication, closure, and recovery** for reportable incidents.

References

- Texas Cyber Command - Report a Cybersecurity Incident
- Texas Government Code Chapter 2063 - Texas Cyber Command (see § 2063.302)
- Texas Business & Commerce Code Chapter 521 - Identity Theft Enforcement and Protection Act
- Texas Education Code § 11.175 - School Cybersecurity
- CISA - #StopRansomware Guide
- U.S. Department of Education - Data Breach Response Checklist